

DALL-E, Generative AI... and Craiyon



I recently came across a book titled ‘Generating Creative Images With DALL-E 3’, from Packt Publishing. It helped me search for answers to questions I didn’t even know existed. Which is why it reinforced my belief that reading a good book can be worth more than sitting for a month in a classroom. You get my drift? My task here is to encourage techies to read, and read a lot!

By way of background (courtesy the Wikipedia), DALL·E, DALL·E 2, and DALL·E 3 are text-to-image models developed by OpenAI. All these use deep learning methodologies to generate digital images from natural language descriptions known as ‘prompts’. In simple words, DALL-E can create “realistic images and art” based on a basic description.

Its first version came out in January 2021, and was initially accessible ‘by invitation only’. But that has changed since.

DALL-E is named after a ‘portmanteau’ (blended word) from the names of the American animated robot Pixar character WALL-E and the Spanish surrealist artist Salvador Dali (1904-1989). One would have never guessed this! In the movie, WALL-E is the solitary robot on a future, uninhabitable, deserted Earth in 2805, left to clean up garbage. By way of trivia, WALL-E’s name stands for Waste Allocation Load Lifter: Earth-Class.

What is Dall-E? What can it do? How does it work? And what about its FOSS fork, which one can access with a few restrictions? Read this book to find out...

But everything is not hunky dory and fun. Today, there are some concerns about DALL-E. This includes its biases when it comes to generating images of race and gender, its potential to be used to create deep fakes and promote misinformation, and the possible ‘technological unemployment’ of artists, photographers and graphic designers due to its accuracy and popularity.

Importantly, OpenAI has not released the source code for any of the three models. So FOSS (free/libre and open source software) attempts have been made to build models with similar capabilities. For instance, Craiyon used to be called DALL-E Mini; but then OpenAI handed in a name-change request. This was based on the original DALL-E trained on unfiltered data.

The India connect

My interest in art (as a hobby, and sometimes for work) drew this book to me. More notable is the number of Indian names associated in the production of this Packt text — Niranjan Naikwadi, Nitin Nainani, Hemangi Lotlikar, Shrishti Pandey, Seemanjay Ameriya, Pratik Shirodkar, Vijay Kambli, and Vinishka Kalra.

Its author, Holly Picano, is an expert in both digital marketing and generative AI. One of the reviewers, Jasdeep Sidhu, is the founder of a generative AI startup and an independent AI consultant.

If you go through the book, it’s hard not to stop at the chapter on how to design a film poster. That is one of the nine chapters in this rather slender 230-page book.

In Part 2 of the book, chapters 4, 5 and 6 look at (not in that order) designing art for covers of books or magazines and other publications; crafting fine art prints with DALL-E 3; and NFTs or non-fungible tokens. (An NFT is a unique digital identifier. It is recorded on a blockchain and used to certify ownership and authenticity. NFTs can be sold and traded, or that’s the theory.)